

The biggest challenge really is coming through all the confusion and uncertainty. Non-WiMAX companies are getting introduced into the marketplace. You have seen the behaviour of companies like Qualcomm and Ericsson, and non-WiMAX companies have spent quite a bit of effort really confusing the marketplace about what is WiMAX, is it ready, is it ready for India and should India make that choice. Much of what I do with people like you, regulatory authorities and service providers is speak the truth about what WiMAX is to customers. We have 149 countries and almost 600 networks, and networks should be growing very, very rapidly. We have a robust roadmap for release 1 and release 2.

What are the areas of improvement for WiMAX to become successful? What are the emerging research areas?

We are spending a lot of time improving the performance of release 1 in the market today. An enhanced release 1 and release 2, both of these will unfold in the next 18-24 months. In parallel, we are trying to make WiMAX more relevant for market segments like aviation, utility and others.

While India is yet to implement the first version completely, other countries are preparing for the second and improved versions. Why the need for WiMAX 2? How does it compare with its predecessor, WiMAX, in terms of speed and coverage area?

While release 1 is a widely deployed WiMAX solution today and delivers the multiple megabit experience on a very efficient all-IP network, consumers' appetite for data is only increasing. We understand this and we have to continue to deliver value into networks. We have a plan to reach 100 MB from where we are today, i.e., 4-5 MB.

On many levels, WiMAX 2 is superior not only in terms of capacity and speed, but it's also cheaper. We have become a worldwide standard for silicon devices to infrastructure for the largest companies in this business for generating volume of scale with power to deliver to India sub-\$30 devices.

Will WiMAX 2 be backwards-compatible with WiMAX?

Yes, WiMAX release-1 devices will work with WiMAX-2 network and WiMAX release-2 devices will work with WiMAX-1 network.

How soon will WiMAX 2 hit the market?

We are currently in the whole technology process of finalising the standard equipment. We anticipate we will be certifying the devices and infrastructure in the second half of 2011. We expect mass-market commercialisation in beginning 2012, which is about the same time when TD-LTE products will first be available in the Indian market.

Speaking beyond India, there is a very vibrant service

provider community in countries like Japan, Korea, USA, Malaysia, Canada, Mexico, and eastern and western Europe that continues to grow. We are also very excited about current industrial applications—smart utility networks, public safety, aviation communication are the future opportunities.

What new business and recruitment opportunities may come up for Indian engineers based on the domestic and global demand?

Huge! We have gathered together at this conference today about 35 of the best and biggest names in equipment manufacturing business from silicon devices to infrastructure. These companies represent a market capitalisation of almost a trillion dollar with sales in 2009 exceeding

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\$700 billion. There is a lot of interest by major names in the Indian marketplace. It's appropriate as certainly India represents for the vendor community a multiple billion dollar opportunity.

How can India be prepared for this?

The hardest step is releasing the spectrum to well-financed visionary and intelligent service providers. Next step is for the service provider community. Right now, they are struggling to make the right decision about whether to choose WiMAX or TD-LTE. So we need now to burn through all the confusion and uncertainty and have some visionary step forward saying I want to lead, I want to capture the market share.

So finally, which technology is going to rule the broadband wireless access (BWA) future: WiMAX, Wi-Fi or 3G?

Wi-Fi is a super technology in a certain niche. It is a great in-building corporate technology or a home technology. 3G is a super technology and it is absolutely excellent in carrying voice. But it's less good for carrying lots of broadband data. This is evidenced by 3G networks in more developed economies. It's still struggling as, at a time when Apple products are increasingly driving mobile video, the networks are really designed for voice. So we see 4G and WiMAX technology as all-IP solution really optimised for what people want to do on their smartphones or even low-end devices. ●